Chapter 17

The Plunge into Stormy Waters: Taming the Waves

The diminutive but dauntless IG (P) immediately plunged into the 'stormy waters' at Tihar. To the complete amazement of both the jail staff and the prisoners, she made frequent rounds of observation, by day and by night, of the four jails. She saw for herself the conditions, heard the prisoners' tales of woe, talked to the staff, looked into the details of the jail's ponderous machinery – and was appalled.

Some of her observations (listed at random), displayed on the notice boards of the various jails, are as follows:

Round 2, Jail 4, 7 May 1993, Ward II:

4. Convicts/prisoners who have come from Jail 2 for treatment in this ward have complained that supplies of drugs and 'smack' are through the warders of Jail 2. This supply is made through convicts who are addicts and drug peddlers. The dispensary of Jail 2 only supplies diazepam as an alternative for drug addicts …
7. One prisoner reported that drugs are supplied through a small hole connecting Jails 1 and 3.
8. One prisoner reported that some warders on night duty also supplied drugs to the prisoners.
9. After *mulaqaats* (meetings with visitors) some prisoners, who are also addicts, take drugs into the jail in their mouth or in bread or in bananas or in soap or in toothpaste or in the heels of their shoes.

Round 5, 13 May 1993:

3. IG(P) directed all jail superintendents to introduce the prayer and reward in every jail before lock-up and after lock-up. The prayer is to be *Aye Malik Tere Bande Ham** (Lord, We Are Your People).

Round 6, 14 May 1993:

6. Vocational training to all the *Munda Khana* (juvenile ward) prisoners will be imparted forthwith. For this purpose, Rs 50,000 will be diverted from each jail's prisoners' welfare fund to Jail 2 immediately.

Round 7 (night round), 16 May 1993:

4. There were a lot of complaints against Assistant Superintendent Ranjit Singh (of